Source: BJP Digital Membership Form on Narendra Modi app, 2020, https://www.narendramodi.in/sadasytaparv2019/card/1562399333286

Some caveats are in order. One could argue that the BJP's membership numbers are exaggerated, that its new technique of using missed calls—wherein anyone giving a missed call on the party's recruitment helpline is enrolled as a member after due verification—could be gamed, or simply that some of these growth numbers were fudged. Certainly, critics who question the party's growth allege this.

Yet, the party's growth on independently verifiable digital platforms also dwarfs that of the RSS. The NaMo app, which the BJP used as the focal point of its recruitment drive, had been downloaded over 10 million times on Google Play Store by August 2020—that is the number of Indians who have physically downloaded the app on their phones, as opposed to only passively receiving the party's messaging. Even this number is more than the maximum estimated strength of the RSS. Similarly, the BJP had almost thrice as many Facebook followers (16 million+) as the RSS (5.5 million) in August 2020. Modi's Facebook followers (45.8 million) were eight times more than the RSS's (5.5 million). We see a similar pattern on Twitter where, by August 2020, the BJP's following (14.5 million) was over six times larger than that of the RSS (2.1 million) and Modi's (61.5 million) was about twenty-nine times bigger (see Figure 8.4).

It is important to remember, of course, that the RSS has historically been media-shy. It is also not a political organisation that fights elections. It does not need to cultivate a social-media presence as the BJP does. Yet, the magnitude of the difference between its reach and that of the BJP's on online platforms mirrors the vast gap in their offline membership estimates too. We can quibble about the exactitude of the reported numbers, but broadly speaking, all reported parameters point in the same direction: the BJP is now many times bigger than the RSS and about double the size of the CCP.